GENDER BENDERS

Prajakta Joshi Vs. Aksh Sorate

Get Cell Phone Accessories

This time round, we wanted to see how the buying habits of the genders differed when it came to the buying of accessories for a cell phone.

Prajakta was hesitant at first to tell us what she wanted, as though she were holding a closely-guarded secret. Then out it came: she said she wanted to buy a memory card, and justified this saying she needed it for her MP3s. She went on to outright reject our generous offer of a 128 MB MMC card, and said she wanted the highest capacity available in the market! And as if that weren't enough, she wanted a pair of headphones, and a mobile pouch of the hang-round-the-neck variety!

We initially thought we'd give our participants whatever they asked for, but after this onslaught, we decided not to...

The instant we told Aksh we'd be giving him any phone accessory he wanted, he outdid Prajakta by saying he wanted an iPod. "iPod"?!? We were befuddled, wondering whether we'd asked our question wrong or whether he hadn't got it right, and decided to repeat our offer. Aksh then said he wanted a 1 GB MMC card with a data cable, and that was the end of that. Quite a decisive person, we should say. When asked if he wanted an accessory to make his phone look jazzier, he didn't seem to like the idea—and went on to say, "Boys want stuff for the utility value and not to flaunt it." We don't quite think that's true, but anyway, we decided to stay out of that argument!

HERE COMES THE SUN

Google Goes Solar

If you haven't heard yet, Google founders Larry Page and Sergey Brin are very environment-conscious and huge fans of alternative energy sources—they were among the first people to adopt hybrid cars when they came out. No surprises, then, that they've decided to take on the biggest solar energy project in the US, hoping that more players from corporate America will follow suit.

Google's 1 million square foot campus at Mountain View, south of San Francisco, will soon get thirty percent of its power from the Sun, they say, pending the installation of around 9,200 solar panels at said campus. The installation will be ready next spring, and once up, the array will generate enough juice to power 1,000 homes. No word on the cost of this whole affair, but we hardly think that it's going to pinch a company with $10 billion in cash. What we do know is that the energy costs that they expect to save will recover the project's cost in five to ten years. Google's concern for these energy costs comes due to their immense power requirements to keep their server farms running and serving the world.

In a world that has been reluctant to adopt solar energy, it is indeed refreshing to note this development.

CUT THE CORD

USB Goes Wireless

Finally! A solution to the mess of cabling that plagues the average desktop. With the growing number of devices that you can connect to your PC via USB, frustrations are reaching alarming highs. Wireless technologies like Bluetooth can't offer the speeds that USB 2.0 does (480 Mbps), so there's been no alternative for the good old cable thus far.

To the relief of the general masses, we should be seeing devices enabled with the wireless version of USB 2.0 later this year. The idea involves replacing the USB cable with tiny radios on both the device and the PC.

The technology will be based on the WiMedia Alliance's Ultra Wide Band (UWB) standard, and promises to deliver the same speeds as USB 2.0 up to a range of three metres, possibly dropping beyond a range of ten metres.

In the real-world usage scenario, it'll probably be difficult to see the 480 Mbps, but the performance will still be much faster and use less power than Wi-Fi.

High-bandwidth wireless technologies have been in development for quite some time now, but standardisation has been delayed by battles between the WiMedia Alliance led by Intel, and the UWB Forum led by Freescale Semiconductor, who showed off a wireless USB hub at the Consumer Electronics Show (CES) earlier this year. Freescale pulled out of the UWB Forum to develop its own wireless USB standard, though, leaving the WiMedia Alliance room to power through.

That this is going to be immensely useful is a no-brainer, but with everyone trying to get their own technology ready first, we wonder if all these "good intentions" are going to be buried under the trash of "Standard Wars". And the precedent is there—we saw it with DVD +R and DVD -R and we'll be seeing it with BluRay and HD-DVD—the last thing the poor consumer needs now is more confusion.

SYMBIAN GOES CLAIRVOYANT

The PC Is Dead

According to the top dogs at Symbian, the PC's days are numbered—we should be seeing the beginning of their end around five years from now. At the Symbian Smartphone Show in London, CEO Nigel Clifford said, "Desktop PCs are a

Buzzword of the MONTH

Wibree

Wibree is a new communication technology developed by Nokia Research Center. It works on radio frequency—2.4 GHz—and is slated for implementation in localised communications. It will support a data transfer rate of 1 Mbps, and it has a range of 5 to 10 metres.

This new technology consumes much less power when compared to other radio technologies such as Bluetooth. It can be used in devices with small form factors, making it ideal for wireless headsets and the like. It's also an ultra-low-cost technology, and can also be used in existing Bluetooth circuitry as an add-on feature, thus drastically reducing implementation costs.

Wibree is an open industry initiative, so one doesn't need to obtain permission to use the technology, and it can be fine-tuned to one's needs.